

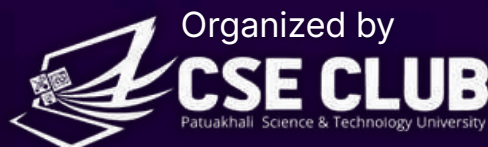


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NATIONAL HACKATHON /> 2026

RULES & PARTICIPANT GUIDELINES

Date: 29 Aug, 2026



RULES & GUIDELINES

This rulebook defines the general participation, development, technology, submission, and operational requirements for the hackathon. The specific problem to be solved will be provided separately in the **Challenge Document**.

1 Hackathon Duration

The development session will run from:

Start: 9:00 AM

Code Freeze / End: 3:00 PM

Total Development Time: 6 Hours (including lunch hour)

Teams must stop active development when the official development period ends. Further instructions regarding demonstration and presentation will be announced by the organizers.

2 What You Are Expected to Build

This is a software development hackathon. Each team must develop a working software solution based on the problem described in the Challenge Document.

Your solution must include:

- ▶ A **user-facing application**, which may be a Web Application or Mobile Application.
- ▶ A **backend/server-side** application responsible for the core business logic and data processing.
- ▶ Appropriate data storage/database where required by your solution.

A responsive web application that works well on mobile devices is completely acceptable.

3 Technology & Programming Language

The hackathon is completely **language and framework agnostic**.

Teams are free to select technologies they believe are appropriate for their solution.

Choose your technology based on your team's skills and engineering decisions.

4 Architecture & Pipeline

There is no prescribed architecture. Teams may choose a monolithic application, modular monolith, microservices, serverless architecture, or another approach. Any design pattern is accepted. The complexity of the architecture itself will not make a solution better.

Teams should be prepared to explain **why their chosen architecture is appropriate for the problem they solved**.

5 AI-Assisted Development

AI tools are allowed.

Teams may use AI-assisted development tools during the hackathon. This includes coding assistants, conversational AI, AI-powered IDEs, and similar development tools. Examples may include ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, GitHub Copilot, Cursor, or other tools available to the participants.

However:

The organizers will not provide AI subscriptions, API keys, credits, tokens, or paid AI accounts.

If a team wishes to use an AI service, it is entirely the team's responsibility to arrange the necessary account, subscription, credits, API tokens, or access beforehand.

Every team is responsible for understanding the code, architecture, algorithms, database design, and engineering decisions contained in its submission.

Teams may be asked to explain any part of their implementation.

6 Internet Connectivity

The organizers intend to provide internet connectivity at the venue. However, approximately 50 teams may be developing simultaneously, and internet performance may vary because of network congestion, technical problems, service interruption, or other unexpected circumstances.

Every team is therefore strongly requested to arrange its own mobile internet connection (as secondary personal backup if needed).

A team's inability to continue development because of venue internet speed or an unexpected internet outage will **not normally result in additional development time**. Please prepare accordingly.

7 Development Environment

Teams are responsible for preparing their development environment before arriving at the venue. This includes installing necessary:

- ▶ IDEs/editors
- ▶ Programming language runtimes
- ▶ SDKs
- ▶ Package managers

- ▶ Database software
- ▶ Mobile development environments
- ▶ Git tools
- ▶ Docker (if you think to use) or other development tools
- ▶ Frameworks and commonly required dependencies

Do not depend on the hackathon internet connection to download several gigabytes of development software after the competition begins. Teams are encouraged to verify their development environment beforehand.

8 Devices & Equipment

Participants must bring the laptops and other normal computing equipment required for development. Teams are responsible for ensuring their devices are charged and operational. Participants should also bring their own chargers and any necessary adapters/cables.

9 Pre-Built Projects

Teams must not arrive with a substantially completed application that already solves the announced challenge and present it as work developed during the hackathon. Generic reusable code, development utilities, personal libraries, boilerplates, project starters, authentication components, UI libraries, and similar foundations may be used. The core business solution specific to the hackathon problem must be developed during the hackathon period. If requested, teams should be able to explain what was developed during the competition.

10 Source Code

Teams must maintain the source code of their solution throughout the competition. Using Git is strongly recommended. The organizers/judges may request access to or inspection of the source code during or after the development period. Better if you can create a git repository and push all of your code before the hackathon time ends.

11 External APIs & Cloud Services

Teams may use external APIs, cloud platforms, hosting providers, databases, authentication providers, mapping services, notification services, and similar technologies. Any such service must be legally accessible to the team.

The organizers will **not guarantee or provide paid third-party services, API credits, cloud credits, or API keys** unless explicitly announced. Teams should therefore avoid making their entire solution dependent on a third-party service they cannot reliably access during the competition.

12 Deployment

A publicly deployed application is welcome but is **not mandatory unless separately announced**. A solution running successfully on a participant's local development environment may be demonstrated. Teams choosing cloud deployment are responsible for their own hosting accounts, credentials, configuration, and associated costs.

13 During the Hackathon

Organizers and judges may visit teams during development. Teams may be asked questions such as:

- ▶ What are you building?
- ▶ What is currently working?
- ▶ How have you approached a particular problem?
- ▶ Which parts were implemented by your team?
- ▶ Why did you make a particular technical decision?

These interactions are part of the hackathon environment. Teams should continue working normally.

14 Code Freeze

At **3:00 PM**, active development must stop unless the organizers announce otherwise. After code freeze, teams may be asked to demonstrate the application and explain their solution. Fixing, adding, or substantially modifying functionality after code freeze is not permitted unless specifically authorized by the organizers.

15 Organizer Decisions

The organizers may provide additional instructions or clarifications during the hackathon where necessary. Any clarification announced officially to all teams becomes part of these rules. In situations not explicitly covered by this document, the organizers' decision will be considered final.

16 Code of Conduct

All participants are expected to maintain honesty, professionalism, and mutual respect throughout the hackathon.

- ▶ Participants must treat organizers, judges, mentors, and fellow teams with courtesy and respect at all times.
- ▶ Any form of harassment, discrimination, or disruptive behavior will not be tolerated.
- ▶ Teams must be honest and transparent when explaining their work; misrepresenting contributions or technical decisions may affect evaluation.
- ▶ Any violation of this code of conduct may lead to warnings, point deductions, or disqualification at the organizers' discretion.

17 Short Recess

Participants may request a short recess for personal needs such as prayer, meals, medical attention, or other genuine reasons. Kindly inform a volunteer or organizer before stepping away from the venue/hall, so attendance and venue coordination are maintained. Recess time will not be counted toward an extension of the development period; teams are advised to plan their time accordingly. Genuine emergencies will be handled with reasonable flexibility at the organizers' discretion.

FINAL REMINDER

The hackathon is not about how many features you can build in six hours.

We encourage teams to build a **working and thoughtfully engineered solution** to the problem presented in the Challenge Document.

Choose your tools wisely, manage your hours carefully, and be prepared to explain the thinking behind what you build.

The evaluation factors will not be bound to only if the features are working well or not. While evaluation judges will care about the

- ▶ Code structure and architecture
- ▶ Code readability
- ▶ Code maintainability
- ▶ Coding design pattern
- ▶ Code comment for understanding of another developer
- ▶ Simplistic development, rather than complex and messy code
- ▶ Scalability
- ▶ Concurrency
- ▶ How many useful features the team members thought and then implemented
- ▶ How nicely the team mates explain the code and its necessity in the project
- ▶ How they thought about new feature implementation with less effort in future
- ▶ Which algorithm they use and why used etc. many more factors

Good luck, and happy building!

EVENT CO-ORDINATOR

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